

The Phone is **Losing You Patients** Every Single Day

Demand for dental care has never been higher — and the front desk has never been more overwhelmed. Here's the data on what's breaking, and exactly how Sara fixes it.

35%

Calls go unanswered

At the average UK dental practice daily

78%

Hang up at voicemail

Don't leave a message — just gone

67%

Call a competitor next

Immediately — no second chance

300

Missed calls/month

Average practice, all hours

82%

Locked out of NHS care

New adult patients, England, May 2025

61%

Staff: high burnout

UK dental professionals, BDJ 2024

THE BACKDROP

The NHS Access Collapse Is Flooding Your Phone Line

Millions of patients can't get an NHS dentist — so they're ringing every practice they can find. The demand is there. The question is who picks up.

82%

of new adult patients couldn't access NHS dental care (England, May 2025) — rising as high as 97% in some areas

2.2M

people each year have unmet NHS dental needs they can't satisfy

48%

of surgeries have no capacity for additional adult NHS patients

73M

units of dental activity delivered across England in 2024-25 — a system at full stretch

Here's the opportunity hiding in the crisis: with NHS lists closed, a flood of patients are **actively searching and phoning private practices**. Every one of those calls is a new patient worth thousands — but only if someone answers. **The practices that pick up first, win.**

THE PROBLEM

Why the Front Desk Is Breaking

Five compounding pressure points hitting receptionists at once — and why none of them are the receptionist's fault



The Phone Never Stops

40–60 inbound calls per day, plus a full waiting room

- During check-in, payments, or chair queries — the phone rings and **nobody**



No-Shows & Diary Gaps

Empty chairs that were never confirmed

- NHS missed-appointment rates reach **23% for children and 32%+ in**

can answer it.

- Lunch, after 5:30pm, weekends:
complete dead zone. Voicemail rate exceeds 50%.
- New patients call once. **They don't try again**. They move on.

deprived areas — chairs sitting empty.

- Every no-show is **wasted clinician time and lost revenue** that a confirmation call would have saved.
- The desk is too busy to chase reminders manually, so **gaps go unfilled**.



Triage With No Training

Clinically complex decisions made by admin staff

- Receptionists must judge pain severity, urgency, and slot priority — **with no clinical qualification**.
- Getting it wrong = **patient safety risk** and potential CQC liability.
- This invisible pressure contributes directly to **emotional exhaustion and turnover**.



Burnout & High Turnover

Staff leaving faster than practices can hire

- **61% of UK dental staff** score "high" on emotional exhaustion (BDJ 2024).
- Receptionists bear rising **patient aggression** as NHS access collapses nationwide.
- Each hire takes **4-8 weeks to replace**. During that gap: phones handled badly, recalls missed, revenue lost.



Patients Want It Instant

The phone is just one of many channels now

- **73% of UK dental searches happen on mobile** — patients expect to book in the moment they decide.
- A fast, simple booking experience lifts completion from **12% to 28%**.
- If the practice can't respond fast, the patient **books with whoever does**.



Admin Overload

Far more than just answering the phone

- **CQC compliance paperwork**, NHS UDA tracking, FP17 submissions — on top of front desk duties.
- Recall and follow-up campaigns done **manually** — patients fall through the gap.
- Practice software adding complexity. **Something always gets dropped** — usually the phone.

WHEN A CALL GOES UNANSWERED

What happens to that patient?

67%

Call the **next dentist** on Google immediately — no retry

78%

Hang up from voicemail **without leaving a message**

~0%

Actually wait, retry, or stick around — **almost nobody**

THE BEFORE & AFTER

Every scenario, side by side

What happens today vs. what happens with Sara

WITHOUT SARA

Busy desk, phone rings

Patient waits on hold, gives up, calls next dentist. Revenue lost silently.

6pm — practice closed

Phone rings, voicemail kicks in. 78% hang up. New patient gone by morning.

Patient books at 9pm on mobile

No one to answer. They scroll to the next clinic and book there instead.

Appointment tomorrow, unconfirmed

No reminder goes out. Patient forgets. Chair sits empty — clinician paid for nothing.

Receptionist is off sick

WITH SARA AI

Busy desk, phone rings

Sara picks up in 2 rings, handles the caller, books them in — team carries on uninterrupted.

6pm — practice closed

Sara answers, takes booking details, confirms appointment. Morning: diary already filled.

Patient books at 9pm on mobile

Sara answers instantly, captures the booking while the intent is hot. Conversion saved.

Appointment tomorrow, unconfirmed

Sara calls/texts to confirm, offers to rebook if needed, fills the gap from the waitlist.

Receptionist is off sick

Locum scrambles, phones neglected, urgent calls missed. Chaos for 1-3 days.

Sara keeps answering every call. Nothing falls through. No cover needed for routine calls.

Patient asks "is my crown covered?"

Receptionist interrupts patient check-in to look it up. Queue backs up.



Patient asks "is my crown covered?"

Sara handles FAQs instantly — hours, prices, parking, recall dates — no interruption.

Receptionist gives notice

4-8 weeks of disruption, job ads, interviews, training. Phones poorly handled throughout.



Receptionist gives notice

Sara continues without a gap. Human hire can focus on higher-value in-clinic work.

BURNOUT DATA

What UK dental staff are actually experiencing

British Dental Journal research, 2024 — dental receptionists and practice managers



"The phone was the worst part of the job. You're mid-sentence with a patient and it rings again and you know you can't get to it. You just feel like you're failing everyone at once."

THE SOLUTION

What Sara AI Does

Not a replacement — an always-on layer that catches everything the team can't reach



Answers Every Call

Every inbound call answered in 2 rings, 24 hours a day, 7 days a week. No voicemail, no hold music, no missed patients.

24/7 Coverage



Books Into the Diary

Sara takes caller details, checks availability, and confirms appointments directly — ready for the team in the morning.

Live Booking



Confirms & Fills Gaps

Sara sends reminders, confirms upcoming appointments, and offers open slots to the waitlist — cutting no-shows and empty chairs.

Fewer No-Shows



Handles FAQs Instantly

Opening hours, prices, parking, recalls, cancellations — Sara answers the routine questions without interrupting your team.

Routine Queries



Works Alongside Your Team

Sara doesn't replace the receptionist — she handles overflow and out-of-hours so your staff can focus on the patients in front of them.



Built for UK Dental Clinics

Understands NHS and private structures, UK terminology, and the way British dental practices actually run.

THE NUMBERS

Sara vs. Hiring a Receptionist

Annual cost comparison for a UK dental practice, 2026

HUMAN RECEPTIONIST

Base salary (England avg)	£26,000
Employer NI (13.8%)	£3,588
Holiday pay (5.6 weeks)	£2,804
Sick cover (avg 7 days)	£700
Training & onboarding	£1,200
Recruitment (if they leave)	£1,500
Total annual cost	~£35,800

SARA AI

Monthly subscription	£299/mo
One-off setup fee	£999
First month	FREE
NI contributions	£0
Sick days	£0
Recruitment	£0
Total annual cost	~£4,587

Annual saving with Sara

Sara works as the overflow + out-of-hours layer — not a full replacement, but even as support she pays for herself in the first month of recovered missed calls.

£31,000+
saved vs. a second hire

REVENUE RECOVERED

A new-patient private exam in the UK now runs around **£80**, and the lifetime value of that patient reaches several thousand pounds. If Sara recovers just **10 new patient calls per month** that would otherwise be missed — at a conservative £650 lifetime value — that's **£6,500/month** in recovered revenue against a £299/month cost. The ROI is not close.

THE TIMING

Why 2026 Is the Year to Fix This

Three forces have converged — the practices that move now capture the patients everyone else is dropping.

01 · DEMAND SURGE

NHS lists are closed

With 82% of new patients locked out of NHS care, private enquiries are flooding in. More calls than ever — and most go unanswered.

02 · BEHAVIOUR SHIFT

Patients book on impulse

73% of searches are on mobile, often after hours. Whoever answers first wins the booking. Speed is now the whole game.

03 · STAFF SHORTAGE

Receptionists are scarce

Burnout and turnover make hiring slow and expensive. Sara fills the gap instantly, with no recruitment cycle and no sick days.

See Sara in Action

Hear exactly what your patients hear when Sara answers the call

£299

FREE

£999

per month

first month

one-off setup

Listen to the Live Demo →

Reply to this email to ask questions · Reply STOP to opt out

SOURCES

- British Dental Journal — burnout & wellbeing of UK dental receptionists (2024)
- NHS England Digital — NHS Dental Statistics 2024-25
- Reach.co — 32% of dental calls go unanswered
- Oral Health Group — UK AI receptionist rollout results
- Dominate Dental — UK dental online booking & acquisition data (2026)
- ONS / Commons Library — NHS dental access, England (2025)
- The Times — survey of NHS surgery capacity
- Resonate AI — missed calls in dental practices statistics
- University of Portsmouth — missed scheduled NHS dental appointments (DNA) study
- MyTribe Insurance — average cost of UK private dental treatment

Sara AI · UK Dental Voice Receptionist · Presented by Jordan · Report refreshed June 2026
All figures cited from published UK sources. No clinic-specific numbers are estimated or invented.